Common Medical Conditions

Patient Information Reference

A plain-language reference covering symptoms, causes, diagnosis, general management and warning signs for common conditions, plus normal vital sign ranges and emergency guidance.

Important: This document is an educational sample dataset created for testing a document-based chatbot. It summarises widely published general medical guidance (for example from the World Health Organization, the US Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, NIH MedlinePlus, the American Diabetes Association and the American Heart Association). It is not a substitute for professional medical advice, diagnosis or treatment, and it does not give medicine doses. Always consult a qualified healthcare professional. In an emergency, contact local emergency services.

Contents

1. Normal Vital Signs and Body Measurements
2. Anemia
3. Type 2 Diabetes
4. Hypertension (High Blood Pressure)
5. Asthma
6. Influenza and the Common Cold
7. Migraine
8. Urinary Tract Infection (UTI)
9. Dehydration
10. Heart Attack (Myocardial Infarction)
11. Stroke
12. Hypothyroidism (Underactive Thyroid)
13. Gastroesophageal Reflux Disease (GERD)
14. General Guidance: When to Seek Emergency Care

1. Normal Vital Signs and Body Measurements

Vital signs are basic measurements of how the body is working. The ranges below are typical for healthy adults at rest; normal values differ for children, older adults, athletes and pregnant women.

Measurement	Typical adult range	Notes
Resting heart rate	60 to 100 beats per minute	Trained athletes may have lower rates, around 40 to 60
Breathing (respiratory) rate	12 to 20 breaths per minute	Measured at rest
Body temperature	About 36.1 to 37.2 C (97 to 99 F)	A temperature of 38 C (100.4 F) or higher is generally considered a fever
Blood pressure	Below 120/80 mmHg	See the Hypertension section for categories
Oxygen saturation (SpO2)	95% to 100%	Levels below about 92% usually need medical assessment
Fasting blood glucose	70 to 99 mg/dL (3.9 to 5.5 mmol/L)	See the Type 2 Diabetes section

Body mass index (BMI)

BMI is weight in kilograms divided by height in metres squared. It is a screening tool, not a diagnosis, and does not distinguish muscle from fat.

BMI (kg/m2)	Category for adults
Below 18.5	Underweight
18.5 to 24.9	Healthy weight
25.0 to 29.9	Overweight
30.0 or higher	Obesity

Some guidelines use lower BMI cut-offs for people of Asian descent because health risks rise at lower BMI values.

2. Anemia

Anemia is a condition in which the blood has fewer healthy red blood cells or less hemoglobin than normal. Hemoglobin is the protein in red blood cells that carries oxygen from the lungs to the rest of the body. When hemoglobin is low, tissues receive less oxygen, which causes many of the typical symptoms.

Common symptoms

- Fatigue and weakness
- Pale or yellowish skin
- Shortness of breath, especially during physical activity
- Dizziness or light-headedness
- Cold hands and feet
- Headaches
- Fast or irregular heartbeat
- Brittle nails or unusual cravings for ice or non-food items (seen in iron deficiency)

Common causes and types

- Iron-deficiency anemia: the most common type worldwide, caused by blood loss (for example heavy menstrual periods or bleeding in the digestive tract), low dietary iron, or poor iron absorption
- Vitamin B12 or folate deficiency anemia: caused by low intake or poor absorption; B12 deficiency can also cause numbness and tingling
- Anemia of chronic disease: linked to long-term conditions such as kidney disease, cancer or chronic inflammation
- Hemolytic anemia: red blood cells are destroyed faster than they are made
- Inherited anemias such as sickle cell disease and thalassemia
- Aplastic anemia: the bone marrow does not make enough blood cells

Diagnosis

Anemia is diagnosed with a complete blood count (CBC), which measures hemoglobin, hematocrit and red blood cell size. The World Health Organization defines anemia in adults as hemoglobin below 13 g/dL in men, below 12 g/dL in non-pregnant women, and below 11 g/dL in pregnant women. Further tests such as ferritin, vitamin B12, folate and a reticulocyte count help identify the cause.

General management

Treatment depends on the cause. Iron-deficiency anemia is usually treated by finding and correcting the source of blood loss and replacing iron through diet and supplements recommended by a clinician. B12 or folate deficiency is treated by replacing the missing vitamin. Anemia caused by another disease improves when that disease is managed. Severe anemia may require a blood transfusion.

Prevention and diet

Foods rich in iron include red meat, poultry, fish, beans, lentils, tofu, dark green leafy vegetables and iron-fortified cereals. Vitamin C (for example citrus fruit) improves the absorption of iron from plant foods, while tea and coffee taken with meals can reduce it. Vitamin B12 is found in meat, fish, eggs and dairy products.

When to seek urgent care

Seek urgent medical care for chest pain, fainting, a very fast heartbeat, severe shortness of breath, or signs of bleeding such as black tarry stools or vomiting blood.

3. Type 2 Diabetes

Type 2 diabetes is a long-term condition in which the body does not use insulin properly (insulin resistance) and, over time, does not make enough insulin. Insulin is the hormone that moves glucose (sugar) from the blood into cells. As a result, blood glucose levels rise. Type 2 diabetes is the most common form of diabetes and often develops slowly over many years.

Common symptoms

- Increased thirst
- Frequent urination
- Increased hunger
- Unexplained weight loss
- Fatigue
- Blurred vision
- Slow-healing sores or frequent infections
- Numbness or tingling in the hands or feet

Risk factors

- Overweight or obesity, especially around the abdomen
- Physical inactivity
- Family history of diabetes
- Age over 35 to 45 years (it is increasingly seen in younger people)
- History of gestational diabetes
- High blood pressure or abnormal cholesterol
- Prediabetes
- Polycystic ovary syndrome

Diagnosis

Diabetes is diagnosed with blood tests. The American Diabetes Association criteria are shown in the table below. A diagnosis usually needs two abnormal results, unless there are clear symptoms with a very high random glucose.

Test	Normal	Prediabetes	Diabetes
HbA1c	Below 5.7%	5.7% to 6.4%	6.5% or higher
Fasting plasma glucose (no food for at least 8 hours)	Below 100 mg/dL (5.6 mmol/L)	100 to 125 mg/dL (5.6 to 6.9 mmol/L)	126 mg/dL (7.0 mmol/L) or higher
2-hour glucose during oral glucose tolerance test	Below 140 mg/dL (7.8 mmol/L)	140 to 199 mg/dL (7.8 to 11.0 mmol/L)	200 mg/dL (11.1 mmol/L) or higher
Random plasma glucose with classic symptoms	-	-	200 mg/dL (11.1 mmol/L) or higher

Possible complications

Poorly controlled blood glucose over time can damage blood vessels and nerves. Complications include heart disease and stroke, kidney disease (diabetic nephropathy), eye damage (diabetic retinopathy), nerve damage (neuropathy), foot ulcers and infections, and gum disease.

General management

Management focuses on keeping blood glucose, blood pressure and cholesterol in a healthy range. Healthy eating, regular physical activity and weight loss are the foundation. Many people also need medicines, which may include tablets or injectable medicines such as insulin; the choice and dose are decided by a clinician. Regular check-ups include HbA1c tests, eye examinations, kidney function tests and foot checks.

Low blood sugar (hypoglycemia)

People who take insulin or certain diabetes tablets can develop low blood sugar. Warning signs include shakiness, sweating, fast heartbeat, hunger, confusion and irritability. It is treated with fast-acting sugar, and severe hypoglycemia with confusion or loss of consciousness is an emergency.

When to seek urgent care

Seek urgent care for very high blood glucose with vomiting, abdominal pain, deep rapid breathing, fruity-smelling breath, severe drowsiness or confusion, or for severe low blood sugar.

4. Hypertension (High Blood Pressure)

Blood pressure is the force of blood pushing against the walls of the arteries. It is written as two numbers: systolic pressure (when the heart beats) over diastolic pressure (when the heart rests between beats), measured in millimetres of mercury (mmHg). Hypertension means blood pressure is consistently higher than normal. It is often called a silent condition because it usually causes no symptoms.

Symptoms

Most people with high blood pressure have no symptoms, which is why regular measurement is important. Very high blood pressure can occasionally cause severe headache, nosebleeds, chest pain, shortness of breath or vision changes.

Blood pressure categories

The table below shows the categories used by the American College of Cardiology and American Heart Association (2017). Many other guidelines, including those of the World Health Organization and European societies, define hypertension as 140/90 mmHg or higher.

Category	Systolic (mmHg)		Diastolic (mmHg)
Normal	Below 120	and	Below 80
Elevated	120 to 129	and	Below 80
Hypertension stage 1	130 to 139	or	80 to 89
Hypertension stage 2	140 or higher	or	90 or higher
Hypertensive crisis (seek care)	Higher than 180	and/or	Higher than 120

Risk factors

- Older age
- Family history
- Overweight or obesity
- High salt intake
- Physical inactivity
- Excess alcohol
- Smoking
- Long-term stress
- Chronic kidney disease, diabetes and sleep apnea

Diagnosis

Hypertension is diagnosed when blood pressure readings are high on several separate occasions. Home or 24-hour ambulatory monitoring helps confirm the diagnosis and rule out white coat hypertension, where readings are high only in a clinic.

Possible complications

Untreated high blood pressure increases the risk of heart attack, stroke, heart failure, kidney disease, vision loss and dementia.

General management

Lifestyle measures lower blood pressure: reducing salt, eating more fruit and vegetables (for example the DASH eating pattern), regular physical activity, maintaining a healthy weight, limiting alcohol and stopping smoking. Many people also need one or more blood pressure medicines chosen by a clinician.

When to seek urgent care

A reading above 180/120 mmHg together with chest pain, shortness of breath, back pain, numbness or weakness, vision changes or difficulty speaking needs emergency care.

5. Asthma

Asthma is a long-term condition of the airways in which they become inflamed and narrow, making it harder to breathe. Symptoms often come and go and can be triggered by allergens, infections, exercise or cold air. With the right treatment most people with asthma can live normal, active lives.

Common symptoms

- Wheezing (a whistling sound when breathing)
- Shortness of breath
- Chest tightness
- Coughing, often worse at night or early in the morning

Common triggers

- Respiratory infections such as colds and flu
- Allergens such as pollen, dust mites, mould and pet dander
- Tobacco smoke and air pollution
- Exercise, especially in cold dry air
- Strong smells and chemical fumes
- Stress and strong emotions

Diagnosis

Asthma is diagnosed from symptoms and lung function tests. Spirometry measures how much and how fast a person can breathe out, and an improvement after a reliever inhaler supports the diagnosis. Peak flow monitoring can track changes over time.

General management

Treatment usually involves inhalers. Reliever inhalers open the airways quickly during symptoms. Controller (preventer) inhalers, often containing an inhaled corticosteroid, reduce airway inflammation when used regularly. A written asthma action plan agreed with a clinician explains daily treatment and what to do when symptoms worsen. Avoiding known triggers and correct inhaler technique are important.

When to seek urgent care

Seek emergency care if breathing is very difficult, the reliever inhaler does not help or is needed very often, the person cannot speak in full sentences, or the lips or fingernails turn blue or grey.

6. Influenza and the Common Cold

Influenza (flu) and the common cold are both respiratory infections caused by viruses, but they are caused by different viruses. Flu is usually more severe and comes on suddenly, while a cold is milder and develops gradually. Antibiotics do not work against viruses.

Feature	Common cold	Influenza (flu)
Onset	Gradual	Sudden
Fever	Rare or mild	Common, often high, lasting 3 to 4 days
Aches	Slight	Common, often severe
Tiredness and weakness	Mild	Common, can last weeks
Sneezing, stuffy nose	Common	Sometimes
Sore throat	Common	Sometimes
Headache	Rare	Common
Serious complications	Rare	Possible, including pneumonia

People at higher risk from flu

- Adults aged 65 and older
- Young children, especially under 2 years
- Pregnant women
- People with long-term conditions such as asthma, diabetes, heart disease or weakened immunity

General management

Most people recover with rest, fluids and relief of symptoms. For people at high risk or with severe illness, a clinician may prescribe antiviral medicine for flu, which works best when started early. Colds usually clear within 7 to 10 days.

Prevention

Annual flu vaccination is the best way to prevent influenza. Regular handwashing, covering coughs and sneezes, and staying home when ill reduce the spread of both flu and colds.

When to seek urgent care

Seek urgent care for difficulty breathing, chest pain, confusion, severe weakness, bluish lips, dehydration, or symptoms that improve and then return with fever and worse cough.

7. Migraine

Migraine is a common neurological condition that causes recurring headaches, usually moderate to severe and often throbbing, typically on one side of the head. Attacks can last from 4 to 72 hours. About one third of people with migraine experience an aura before or during the headache.

Common symptoms

- Throbbing or pulsing headache, often on one side
- Sensitivity to light and sound
- Nausea and sometimes vomiting
- Headache made worse by routine physical activity
- Aura: temporary visual changes such as flashing lights or zigzag lines, or tingling on one side of the body

Common triggers

- Stress
- Lack of sleep or changes in sleep pattern
- Skipped meals or dehydration
- Hormonal changes, for example around menstruation
- Certain foods and alcohol
- Bright lights, loud noise and strong smells

General management

Treatment includes medicines taken at the start of an attack to relieve symptoms and, for frequent migraines, preventive treatment chosen by a clinician. Resting in a dark, quiet room helps many people. A headache diary can identify personal triggers. Frequent use of pain relievers can cause medication overuse headache.

Warning signs that need urgent care

Seek emergency care for a sudden, extremely severe headache (thunderclap headache), headache with fever and stiff neck, headache after a head injury, headache with confusion, weakness, numbness, loss of vision or difficulty speaking, or a new headache pattern after age 50.

8. Urinary Tract Infection (UTI)

A urinary tract infection is an infection anywhere in the urinary system, most often the bladder (cystitis). Most UTIs are caused by bacteria from the bowel entering the urethra. UTIs are much more common in women because the urethra is shorter.

Common symptoms

- Burning or pain when urinating
- Needing to urinate often or urgently
- Passing small amounts of urine
- Cloudy, dark or strong-smelling urine
- Blood in the urine
- Pain in the lower abdomen

Signs of kidney infection

Fever, chills, pain in the back or side (flank pain), nausea and vomiting may mean the infection has reached the kidneys (pyelonephritis), which needs prompt medical treatment.

Diagnosis

Diagnosis is based on symptoms and a urine test. A urine dipstick or urinalysis looks for signs of infection, and a urine culture identifies the bacteria and which antibiotics will work.

General management

Bacterial UTIs are treated with antibiotics prescribed by a clinician. Drinking enough fluids helps. Recurrent infections, infections in men, children or pregnant women, and kidney infections need medical assessment.

Prevention

Drinking enough water, not holding urine for long periods, urinating after sexual intercourse and wiping from front to back may reduce the risk.

9. Dehydration

Dehydration happens when the body loses more fluid than it takes in. It can be caused by diarrhoea, vomiting, fever, heavy sweating, hot weather or not drinking enough. Infants, young children and older adults are at the greatest risk.

Signs in adults

- Thirst
- Dark yellow, strong-smelling urine
- Passing urine less often
- Dry mouth, lips and eyes
- Tiredness, dizziness or light-headedness
- Headache

Signs in babies and young children

- Fewer wet nappies (diapers)
- Sunken soft spot on the top of the head
- Few or no tears when crying
- Drowsiness or irritability
- Cold, blotchy hands and feet

General management

Mild dehydration is treated by drinking more fluids, taking small frequent sips if vomiting. Oral rehydration solution (ORS), which contains the correct balance of water, salts and sugar, is recommended for dehydration caused by diarrhoea and vomiting. Severe dehydration may need fluids through a drip in hospital.

When to seek urgent care

Seek urgent care for confusion, fainting, no urination for 8 hours or more, a very fast heartbeat, inability to keep fluids down, or a very drowsy or floppy baby or child.

10. Heart Attack (Myocardial Infarction)

A heart attack happens when blood flow to part of the heart muscle is blocked, usually by a blood clot in a coronary artery narrowed by fatty deposits. Without quick treatment, the heart muscle begins to die. A heart attack is a medical emergency and fast treatment saves lives.

Warning signs

- Chest pain, pressure, squeezing or fullness that lasts more than a few minutes or goes away and comes back
- Pain or discomfort spreading to one or both arms, the back, neck, jaw or stomach
- Shortness of breath
- Cold sweat
- Nausea or vomiting
- Light-headedness or sudden dizziness

Differences in symptoms

Women, older adults and people with diabetes are more likely to have less typical symptoms, such as shortness of breath, unusual tiredness, nausea, or back or jaw pain, sometimes without obvious chest pain.

What to do

Call the local emergency number immediately. Do not drive yourself to hospital. Emergency services can begin treatment on the way. If the person becomes unresponsive and is not breathing normally, start cardiopulmonary resuscitation (CPR) and use an automated external defibrillator (AED) if available.

Risk factors

- High blood pressure
- High cholesterol
- Smoking
- Diabetes
- Obesity and physical inactivity
- Family history of early heart disease
- Older age

11. Stroke

A stroke happens when the blood supply to part of the brain is cut off, either by a blockage (ischemic stroke, the most common type) or by bleeding in the brain (hemorrhagic stroke). Brain cells begin to die within minutes, so a stroke is a medical emergency. Early treatment reduces brain damage and disability.

Recognising a stroke: BE FAST

- B - Balance: sudden loss of balance or coordination
- E - Eyes: sudden loss of vision or double vision
- F - Face: one side of the face droops
- A - Arms: weakness or numbness in one arm; it drifts down when both arms are raised
- S - Speech: slurred or strange speech, or difficulty understanding
- T - Time: call emergency services immediately and note the time symptoms started

Transient ischemic attack (TIA)

A TIA, sometimes called a mini-stroke, causes stroke symptoms that go away within minutes to hours. It is a warning sign of a possible future stroke and needs urgent medical assessment even if symptoms have gone.

Why time matters

Some treatments for ischemic stroke, such as clot-dissolving medicine or clot removal, work only within a limited time after symptoms begin. This is why noting the time of onset and getting to hospital quickly is essential.

Risk factors

- High blood pressure (the most important modifiable risk factor)
- Atrial fibrillation
- Smoking
- Diabetes
- High cholesterol
- Obesity and physical inactivity
- Excess alcohol
- Older age and family history

12. Hypothyroidism (Underactive Thyroid)

Hypothyroidism means the thyroid gland in the neck does not make enough thyroid hormone. Thyroid hormone controls how the body uses energy, so low levels slow down many body functions. It is more common in women and older adults.

Common symptoms

- Tiredness and low energy
- Feeling cold
- Weight gain
- Constipation
- Dry skin and hair, or hair thinning
- Low mood
- Slow heart rate
- Muscle aches
- Heavy or irregular menstrual periods

Common causes

The most common cause in many countries is Hashimoto's thyroiditis, an autoimmune condition in which the immune system attacks the thyroid. Worldwide, iodine deficiency is also an important cause. Other causes include thyroid surgery, radioactive iodine treatment and some medicines.

Diagnosis

Hypothyroidism is diagnosed with blood tests. A high thyroid-stimulating hormone (TSH) level with a low free thyroxine (T4) level indicates hypothyroidism.

General management

It is usually treated with daily thyroid hormone replacement (levothyroxine). The dose is adjusted by a clinician based on regular blood tests, and treatment is usually lifelong.

13. Gastroesophageal Reflux Disease (GERD)

GERD is a condition in which stomach acid frequently flows back into the esophagus (the food pipe), irritating its lining. Occasional heartburn is common; GERD is diagnosed when reflux happens often or causes complications.

Common symptoms

- Heartburn: a burning feeling in the chest, often after eating or when lying down
- Regurgitation of sour liquid or food
- Difficulty or discomfort swallowing
- Chronic cough, hoarseness or sore throat
- Feeling of a lump in the throat

Common triggers

- Large or late meals
- Fatty or spicy foods
- Chocolate, caffeine, alcohol and carbonated drinks
- Smoking
- Being overweight
- Lying down soon after eating
- Pregnancy

General management

Lifestyle changes help many people: eating smaller meals, avoiding trigger foods, not eating within 2 to 3 hours of bedtime, raising the head of the bed, losing weight if overweight and stopping smoking. Medicines that neutralise or reduce stomach acid may be recommended by a clinician.

Alarm features that need medical assessment

Difficulty swallowing that is getting worse, painful swallowing, unintended weight loss, vomiting blood, black stools, anemia, or new symptoms after age 55 to 60 need prompt medical assessment. Chest pain should never be assumed to be heartburn without considering a heart cause.

14. General Guidance: When to Seek Emergency Care

Call the local emergency number immediately for any of the following:

- Chest pain or pressure, especially with shortness of breath, sweating or pain spreading to the arm, jaw or back
- Signs of stroke: face drooping, arm weakness, speech difficulty, sudden vision loss or loss of balance
- Severe difficulty breathing, or blue or grey lips or face
- Sudden, extremely severe headache
- Loss of consciousness, seizure, or sudden confusion
- Severe bleeding that does not stop with pressure
- Severe allergic reaction: swelling of the face, lips or throat, difficulty breathing, or widespread hives after a trigger
- Vomiting blood or passing black, tarry stools
- Thoughts of self-harm or suicide: contact emergency services or a local crisis line

Seek same-day medical advice for

- High fever that does not come down, or fever in a baby under 3 months
- Signs of dehydration that do not improve with fluids
- Painful urination with fever or back pain
- Symptoms that are getting steadily worse

This reference provides general information only. Symptoms can have many causes, and only a qualified healthcare professional can make a diagnosis or recommend treatment.